

Shocker

Venus Williams (right) is bounced from Australian Open in third round by Lisa Raymond. Page C5



DOUG CLARKE

Hype too much: Days numbered for Super Bowl

Of all things ... Been trying to talk the Princess Bride into finally taking that Bullpark Vacation this summer that I've been hankering for. The trip would entail visits to major-league and minor-league ballparks. We're going to go to New Hampshire and South Carolina ... and then on to Georgia ... and Michigan ... and West Virginia ... and Wisconsin ... and New York ... and Illinois ... and California ... and ... But in the meantime ...

Just as a blind squirrel finds an acorn once in a blue moon, it could be that Cavaliers GM Jim Paxson has stumbled upon a couple of trades that will actually serve the team well. The irony is that while he hasn't actually added talent to the roster — he deleted it by trading away Precarious Darius and Wrong Run Ricky — the team is much better off without Miles and Davis.

The way is now clear to build a team around LeBron James and Carlos Boozer and, providing he can stay healthy, Dajuan Wagner. We have, of course, as much confidence in Paxson's ability to do this as we do in Gordon Gund's ownership.

Which is to say this pair has every bit as much chance to succeed as 100 monkeys typing on 100 typewriters coming up with one cogent sentence. Not that that can't be entertaining ... and Indiana ... and Arizona ... and ...

Of all the Super Bowls I've skipped, this one will be the last.

Mark my words, the time will come when the actual playing of the Super Bowl will be canceled. It will be discovered that during the two-week waiting period half the fans will have forgotten about it — with the other half just flat out worn down to a nub by advertising, promo, pregame specials and general silliness and hoopla. An announcer will come on the air and say, "We've played and replayed this game every which way we can for two weeks now and there is simply no use in playing the game. We've covered every possible outcome and the playing of the game would be redundant."

Also, we've bored you stiff, so goodbye from Super Bowl XXXIX. And now, stay tuned for a special program: "Friends: The Reunion."

Scott ("I'm Talking to Five or Six Clubs") Bove still hasn't found a home for World Series hero and All-Star catcher Ivan Rodriguez or pitcher Greg Maddux.

Odds are not splendid that I-Rod will end up in Detroit. We still can't get over the fact that Detroit owner Michael Ilitch actually bid against himself when he came up with that asinine four-year, \$40 million contract offer. Rodriguez may become the first big-time player ever to sit out until May 1 so he can rejoin his old (Marlins) team.

The line on Maddux is that he's taking his time "talking to owners" (interviewing them, as it were) and "is in no rush to sign." Bullpuppy. The offers for Maddux, 38, have dwindled so

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SPORTS

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Section C

Saturday, January 24, 2004

Browns believe in Butch

Davis gets extension through 2007

Steve King
The Chronicle-Telegram

BEREA — It took a while to finalize, but the Browns followed through Friday on something reported a week ago — the signing of coach Butch Davis to a two-year contract extension.

Davis

The deal locks up Davis through the 2007 season. The five-year, \$16 million contract he signed when hired in January 2001 runs through 2005. Financial terms of the extension were not available, but based on the numbers of the original deal, it is believed to be worth approximately \$3.5 million per year. The Browns had originally

planned to announce Davis' extension and the hiring of former Green Bay Packers general manager Ron Wolf as a part-time consultant at the same time. Wolf is expected to come on board within the week. "We are dedicated to providing Cleveland with a championship-caliber football team, and I believe the foundation for this begins with continuity

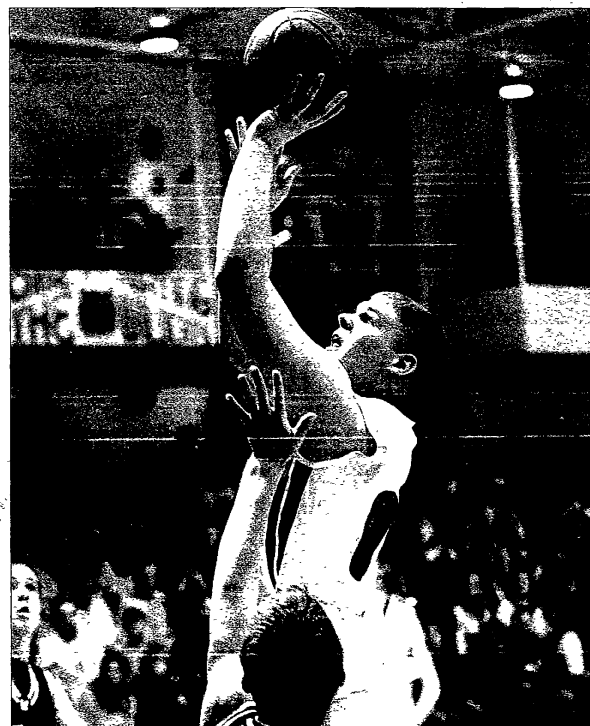
at the top," owner Randy Lerner said in a statement. "I have total faith in Butch Davis as a person and as a head coach to lead us in the right direction." The aggregate of successful experiences accumulated during the careers of (president) Carmen Policy and Butch Davis give me the utmost confidence in our plan. They both have been winners at the high-

est level of their respective professions."

The announcement comes at a key time for Davis, giving him a much-needed boost after a disastrous 3-11 finish. The extension makes it clear to everybody involved that Davis is the coach for the foreseeable future, and gives him stability working with his assistant coaches and, more importantly, acquiring free agents.

See BROWNS, C8

BOYS BASKETBALL



Chase Clowser rises above the Dukes on Friday during Keystone's 66-51 win. Clowser had 14 rebounds and 13 points.

Scales' 3s key Bulldogs get past Cornets

Roger Negin
The Chronicle-Telegram

OLMSTED FALLS — Olmsted Falls is in its customary spot in the Southwestern Conference standings, largely because Jamar Scales was in the wrong place.

Scales, not known as an outside shooter, hit two big 3-pointers in the fourth quarter Friday to key a Bulldog surge that netted a 64-58 SWC victory over Amherst.

The Bulldogs outscored the Cornets 23-19 in the final eight minutes, sinking 11 of 16 free throws and winning the battle of the boards 13-2. But Scales' threes played no small part.

See FALLS, C3



INSIDE

POUNCE EARLY: Elena erupts in first half, routs Berea, C2

STRONG LATE: Avon outscouts Midview 12-2 in overtime, C3

EAGLES OVERCOME: Cold foul shooting can't stop North Olmsted, C2

'Cats roll along

Kevin Aprile
The Chronicle-Telegram

LaGRANGE — Don't get him wrong. Greg Morgan is glad he doesn't have to stay up nights devising ways to keep Brett Bartlett from taking over games with his quickness and deft shooting touch.

And he'll be the first to tell you he's grateful he never has to worry about trying to keep 6-foot-8, 325-pound Chase Clowser from manhandling one of his teams in the post. He's also thankful he doesn't have to spend a minute of time worrying about ways to

curb the enthusiasm of the Bantlosky brothers.

Then again, if Morgan ever did have to come up with a strategy to stop his unbeaten Keystone Wildcats, he's pretty sure he wouldn't worry quite as much about the offensive end of the court.

"If I'm scouting us, I'm more concerned with our defense than our offense," said Morgan after his 'Cats improved to 14-0 overall and 8-0 in the Lorain County Conference with a 66-51 win over Wellington.

See 'CATS, C3

CAVALIERS

James talks trade

LeBron sorry to see buddy Miles depart

Brian Dulk
The Chronicle-Telegram

CLEVELAND — LeBron James and Darius Miles were inseparable from the day the Cavaliers won the NBA Draft lottery.

It's not surprising, then, that James took the news of Miles' trade to the Portland Trail Blazers quite hard.

"It's real tough to deal with," said James, who worked out with Miles throughout the summer at Gund Arena. "He's my best friend on the team. I hated to see him go, but I hope he does well in Portland."

"I do understand it's a business."

James spoke to the media following Cleveland's 85-89 loss to the Sacramento Kings on Thursday night — one day after the Cavaliers dealt Miles to the Trail Blazers in exchange for Jeff McInnis and Ruben Boumtje Boumtje.

Though the swap meant James lost a friend on the club, he also gained a veteran point guard in McInnis who can make his job much easier on the court.

"It'll help our team a lot," James said. "We needed another guy that can help with the ball, and we've got that."

James is expected to miss his third straight game tonight vs. Philadelphia with a sprained right ankle. The team said he was at practice Friday but did not take part in running drills.

James was quite visible Thursday night, even in his absence. He paced in front of the scorer's table during timeouts, showing the time he spent in the training room before the

See CAVS, C4

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